air forum | WASHINGTON, D.C.
May 26-29, 2026
Pre-Conference: May 25-26, 2026

celebrating 60 years air

Accessibility Meets Analytics- Designing Inclusive Power BI Dashboards



Lakshmi Ponnurasan

Imagine a world built for people with disabilities instead of one where they're forced to adapt….



Link

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Accessibility isn’t optional…

it’s a necessity.

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Accessibility Meets Analytics- Designing Inclusive Power BI Dashboards



Lakshmi Ponnurasan

Hi, It's me!



Power BI DataViz 2025 & 2026

WORLD CHAMPIONSHIP FINALIST

Microsoft CERTIFIED POWER BI DATA ANALYST ASSOCIATE

MVP Microsoft® Most Valuable Professional

Missouri S&T

Data Analyst - Institutional Effectiveness







DIVERSITY &INCLUSION

Santhana Lakshmi Ponnurasan

Turning data into insights. Insights into impact.

Game Plan

Game Plan

01 Digital Accessibility



Game Plan

01 Digital Accessibility

02 What Accessibility Actually Means in Power BI?



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Game Plan

01 Digital Accessibility

02 What Accessibility Actually Means in Power BI?

03 Common Accessibility Problems in Dashboards



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Game Plan

01 Digital Accessibility

02 What Accessibility Actually Means in Power BI?

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04 Core Accessibility Features in Power BI (Demo)



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05 BONUS: Your Accessibility Audit Checklist



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03 Common Accessibility Problems in Dashboards

04 Core Accessibility Features in Power BI (Demo)

05 BONUS: Your Accessibility Audit Checklist



WARNING This is not a sit-back session.....
expect to participate, react, and experience the dashboards.

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Digital Accessibility

Digital Accessibility

Digital accessibility means designing digital products and experiences so that everyone can use them effectively, regardless of:



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What Accessibility Actually Means in Power BI?



What Accessibility Actually Means in Power BI?

VCAN Principle



Visual

Make information easy to see and understand for everyone.

What Accessibility Actually Means in Power BI?

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Cognitive

Present content in clear, simple, and consistent ways that reduce cognitive load.

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Present content in clear, simple, and consistent ways that reduce cognitive load.



Assistive

Ensure compatibility with assistive technologies like screen readers and voice control.

What Accessibility Actually Means in Power BI?

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Navigation

Enable intuitive and efficient navigation using keyboards and other input methods.

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Common Accessibility Problems in Dashboards



Common Accessibility Problems in Dashboards

Tiny fonts & low contrast

Text that strains the eye- especially on dark backgrounds or in dense table



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Color-only status indicators fail users with color-vision deficiency.



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Overloaded filter panes create cognitive overwhelm and unclear interactions.



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Tooltip-only information

Critical data hidden in tooltips is invisible to screen readers and keyboard users.

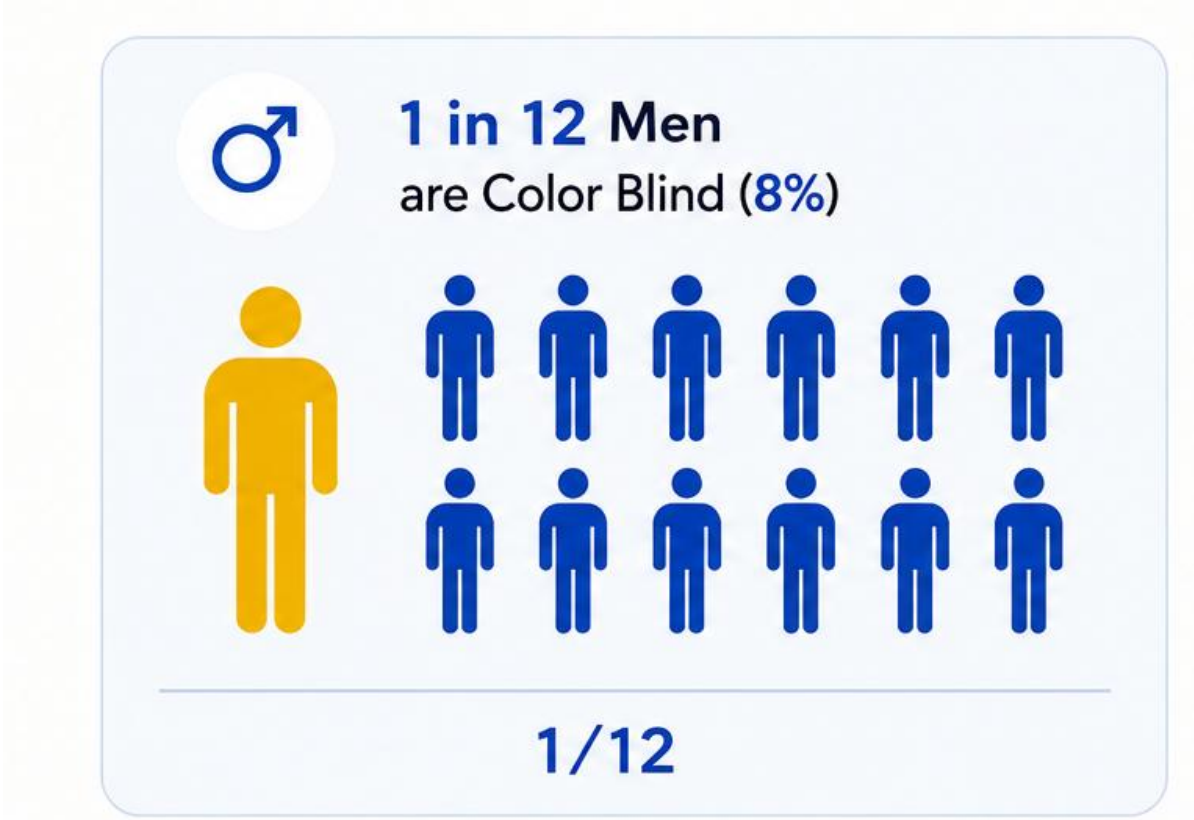


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Core Accessibility Features in Power BI

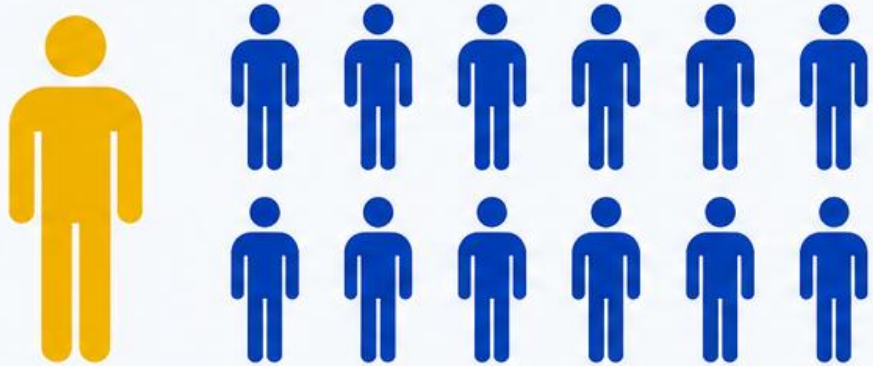
1. Color & Contrast





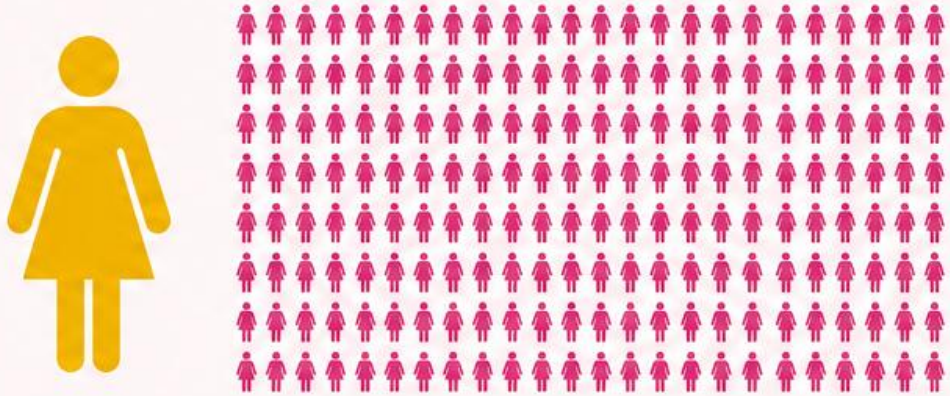
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1 in 12 Men
are Color Blind (8%)



1/12

1 in 200 Women
are Color Blind (0.5%)



1/200

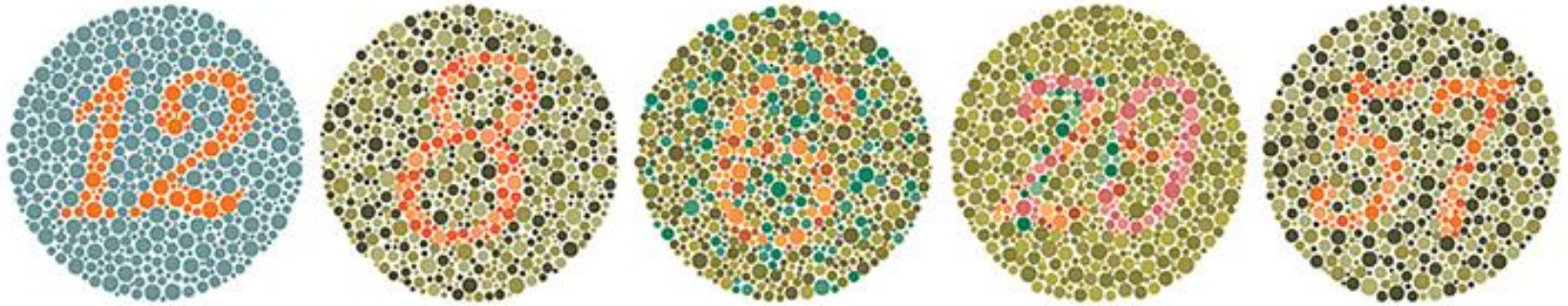
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LOOKING FOR A VOLUNTEER TO STEP IN!

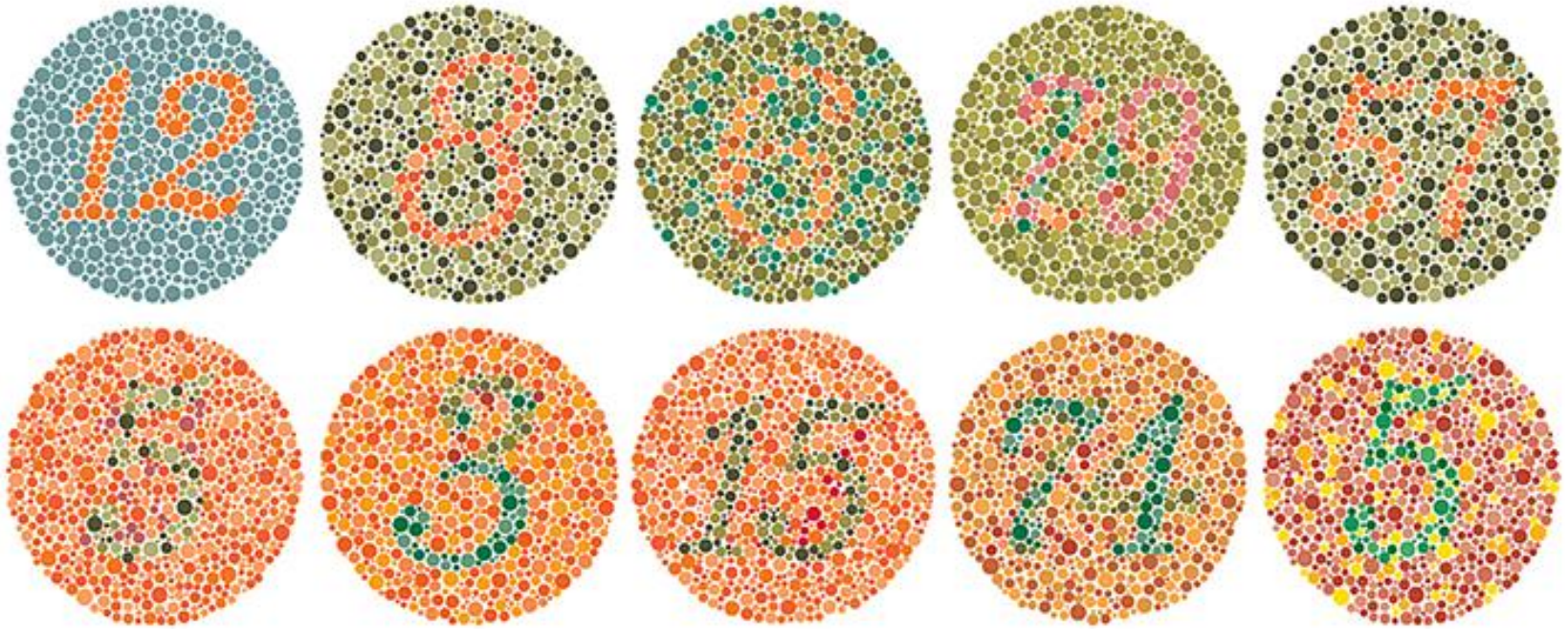


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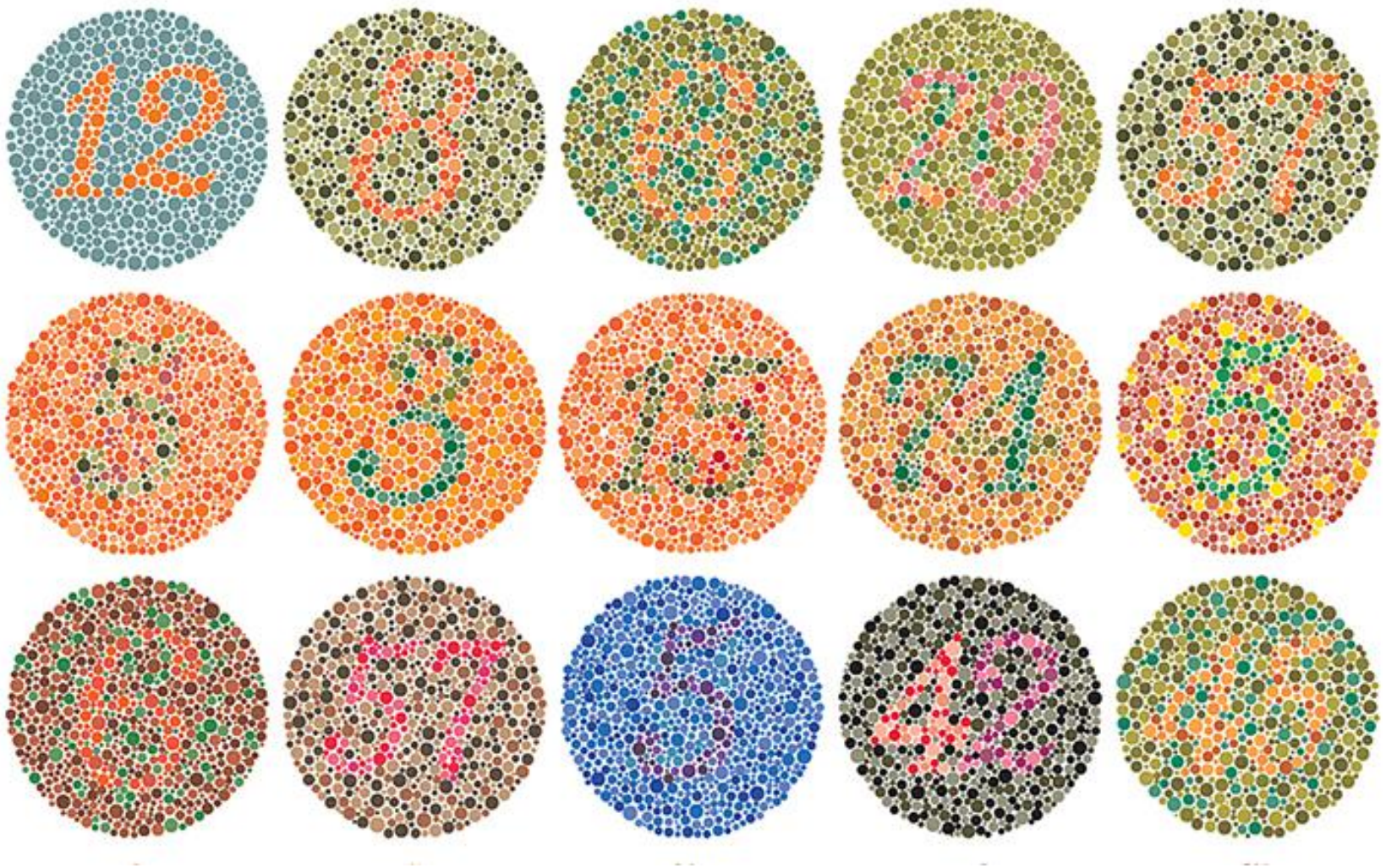
1. Color & Contrast



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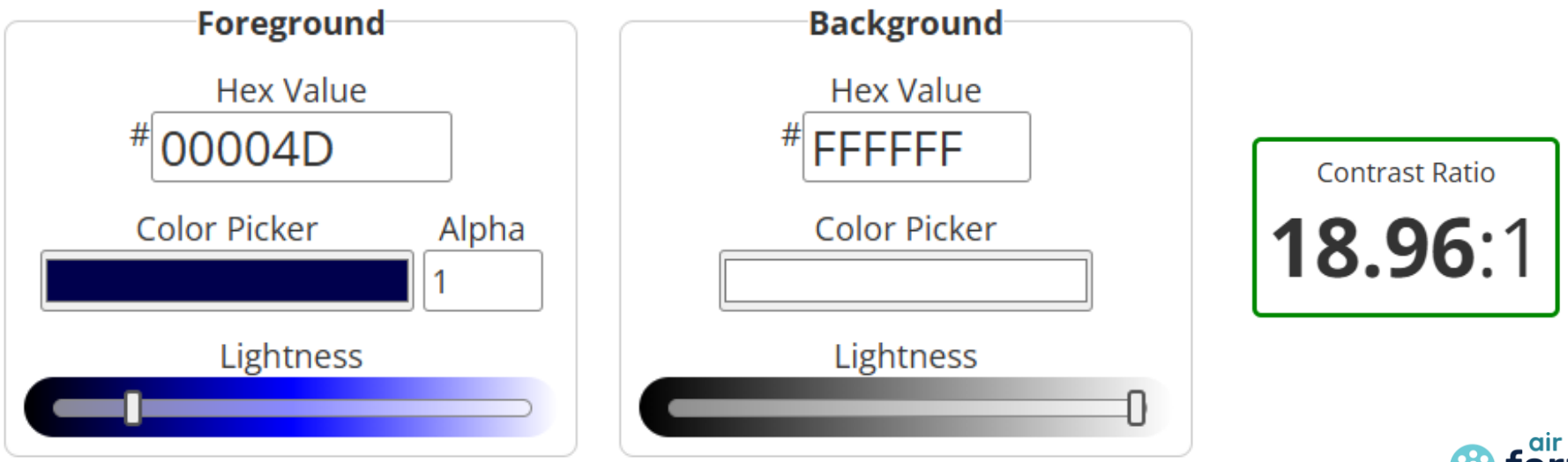
1. Color & Contrast



1. Color & Contrast

⟶ **Meet WCAG AA contrast**
Aim for a minimum **4.5:1 ratio** for normal text and 3:1 for large text or UI components.

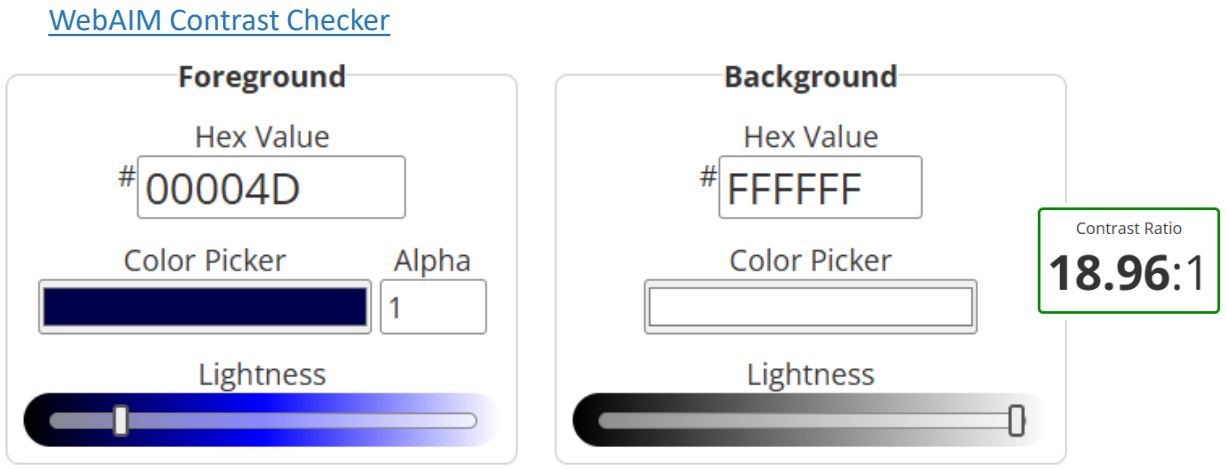
WebAIM Contrast Checker



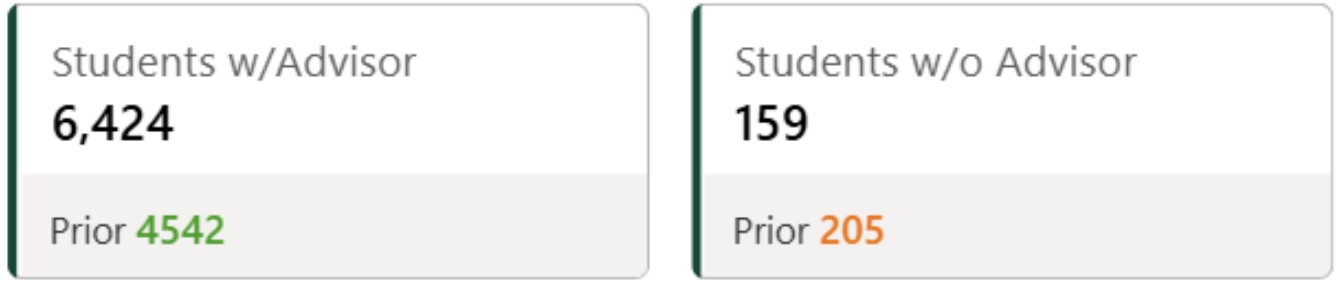
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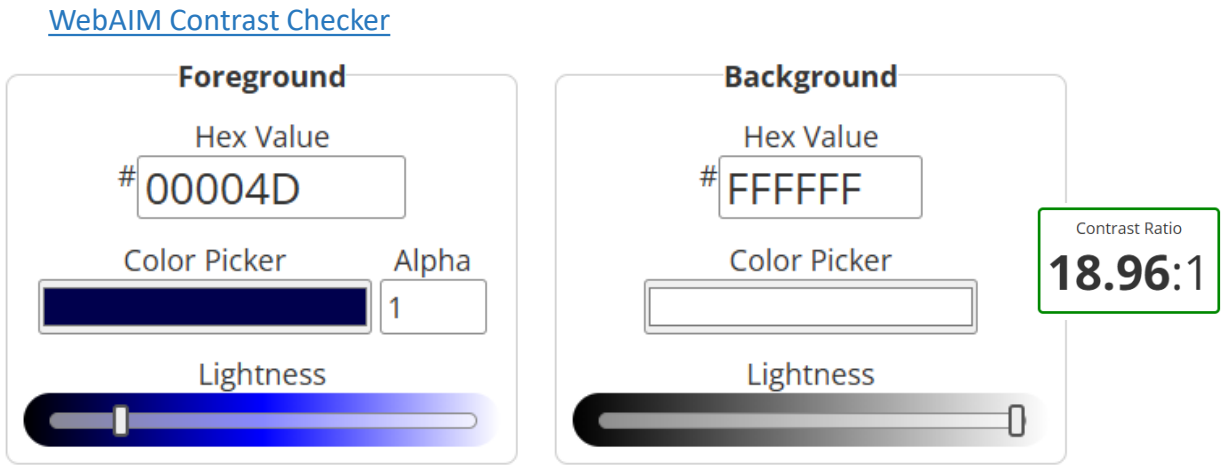
→ **Never use color alone**
Pair red/green status with icons, labels, or patterns- never rely on hue to convey meaning.



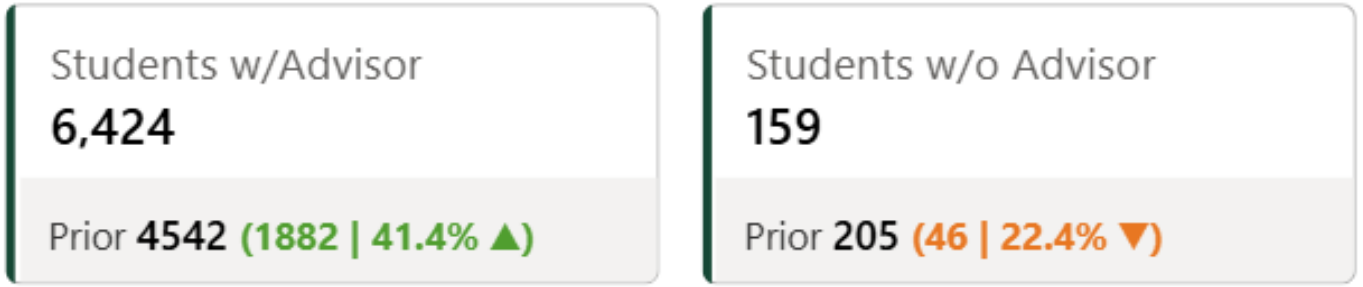
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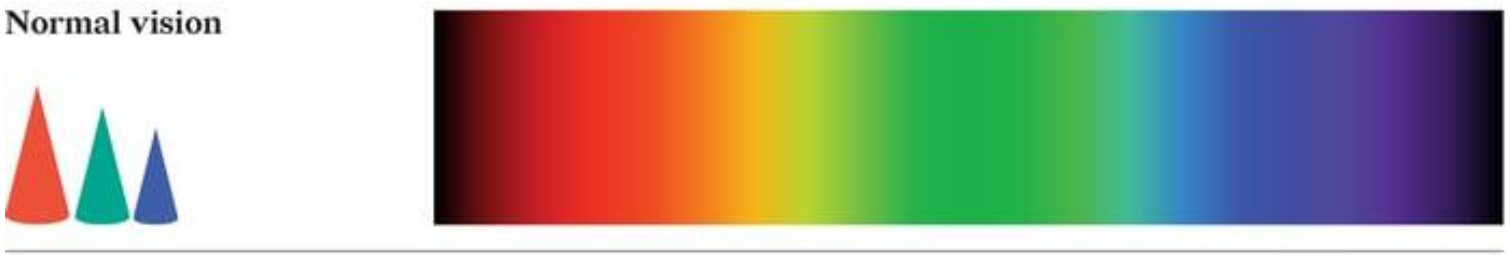
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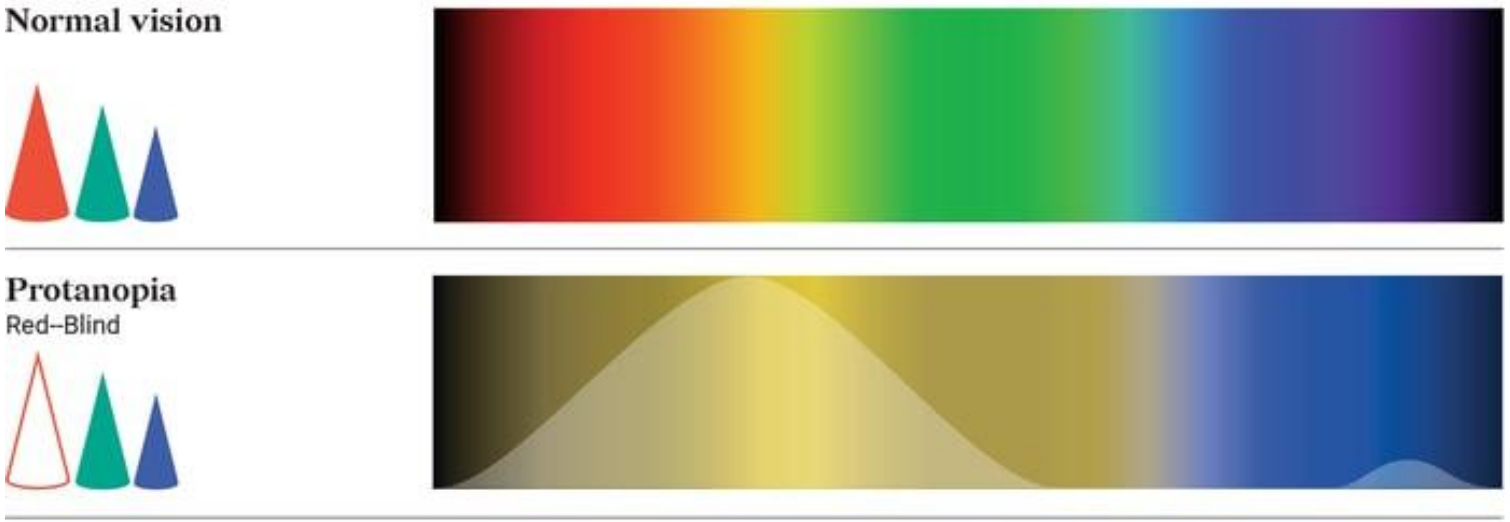
https://daltonlens.org/colorblindness-simulator

Types of Color Blindness



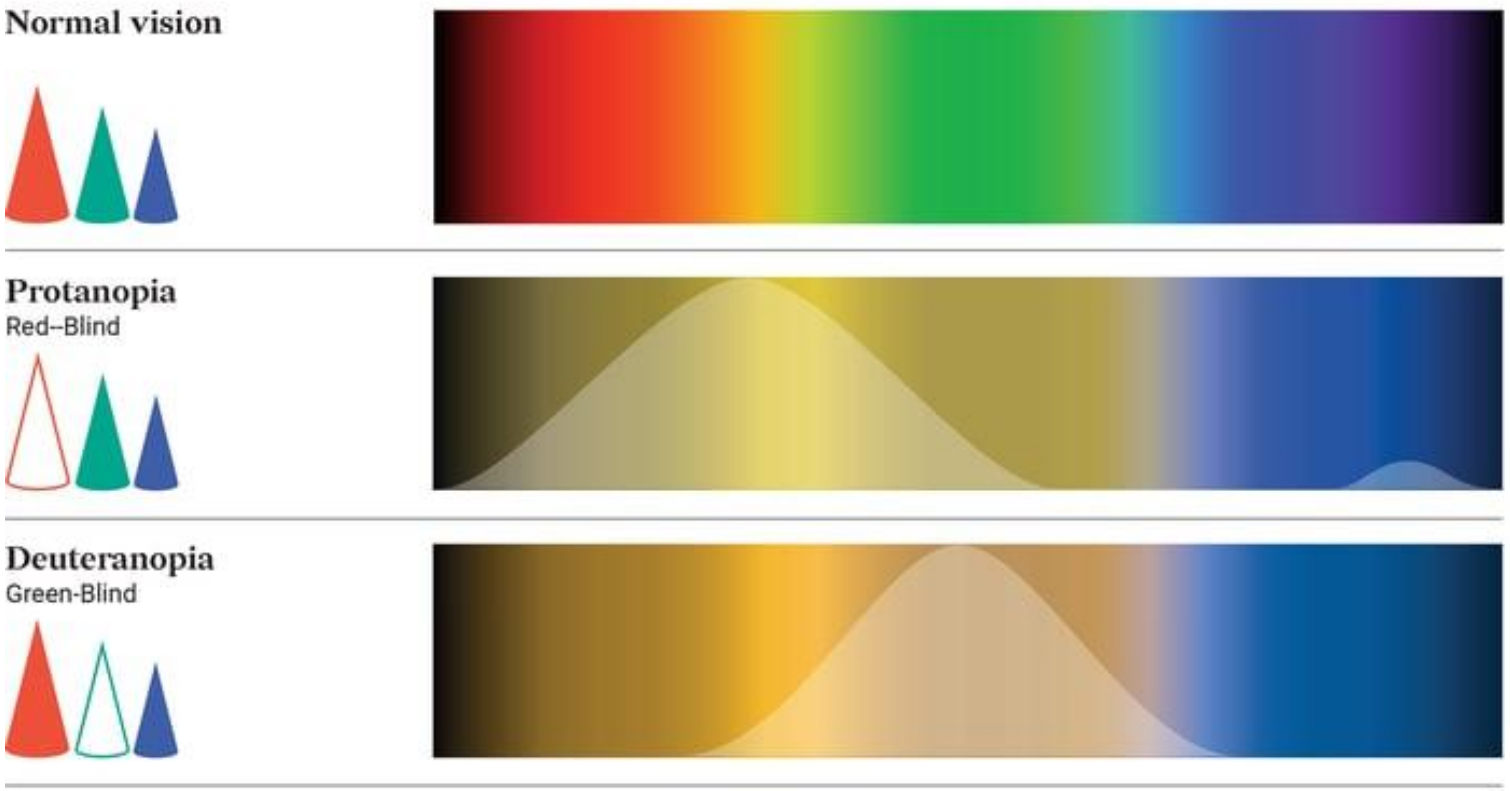
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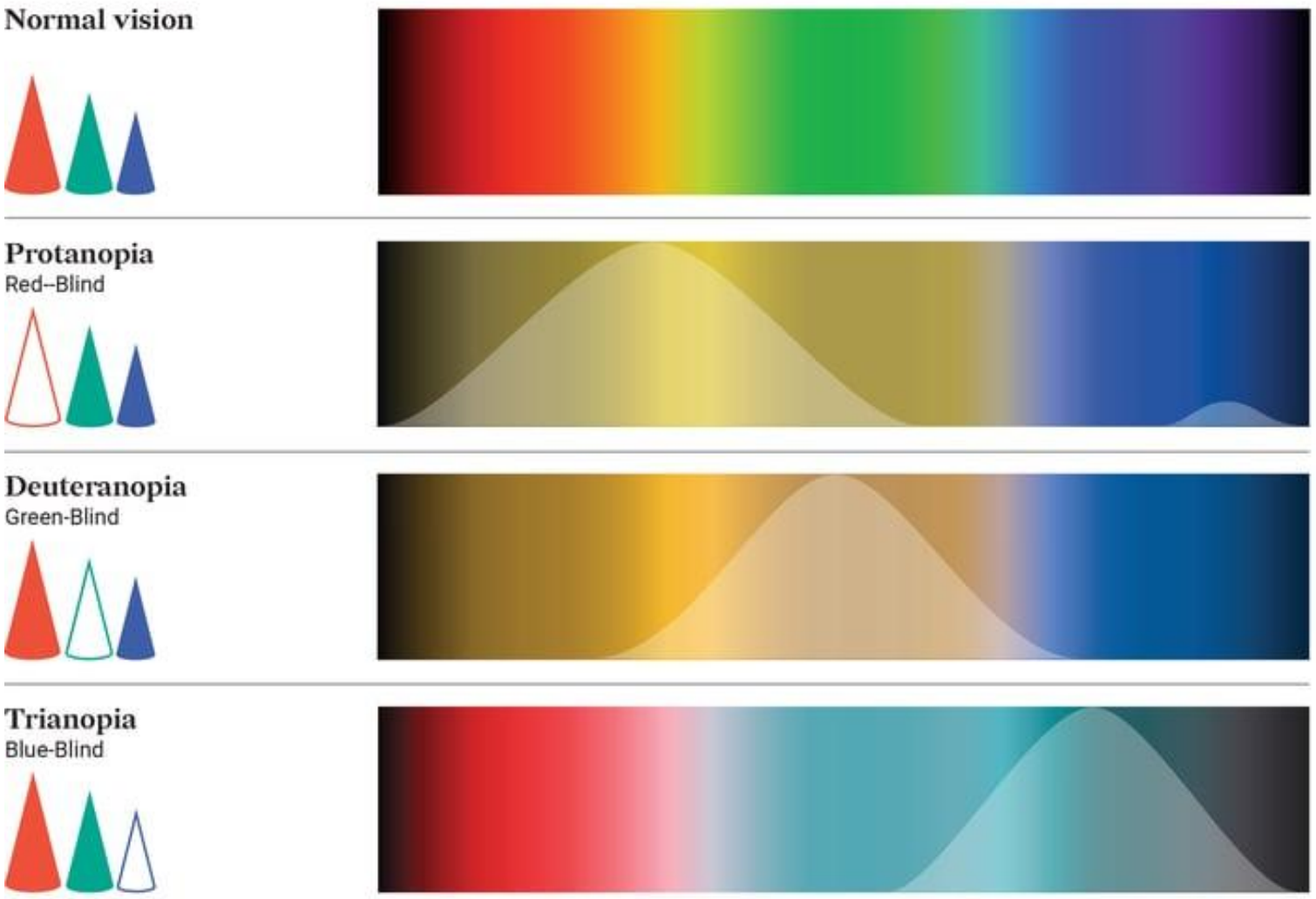
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Types of Color Blindness



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Power BI Snapshots

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UNIVERSITY OF FABRICLAND

Advising

Advisor Name: All

Acad Plan: CHEM

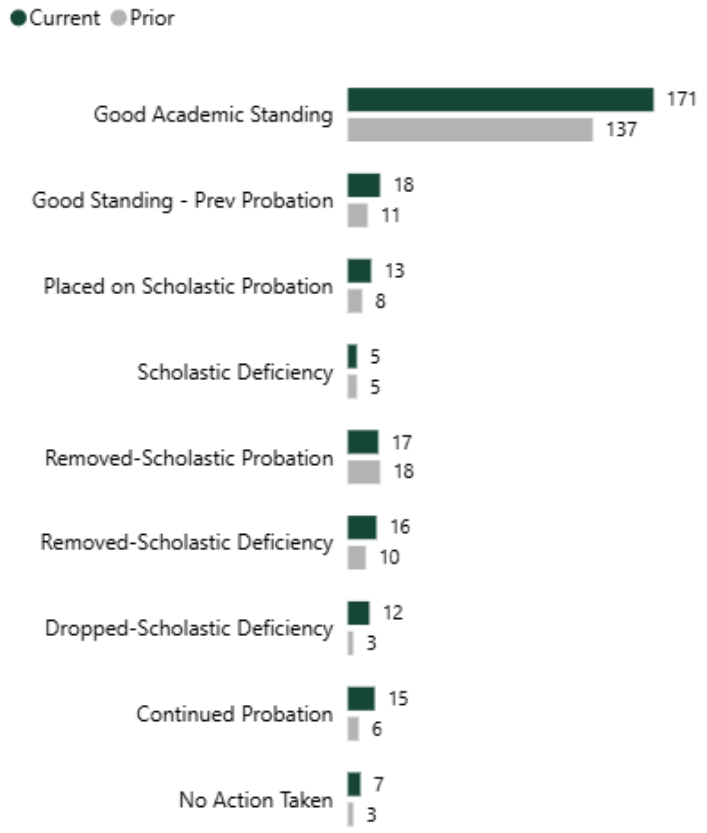
Students w/Advisor	Students w/o Advisor
271	3
Prior 196 (75 | 38.3% ▲)	Prior 5 (2 | 40.0% ▼)

Students w/Acad Standing	Students Scholastic Probation	Less than Full Time #	
274	33	51	
Prior 201 (73 | 36.3% ▲)	Prior 19 (14 | 73.7% ▲)	UGRD #	GRAD #
		51	--

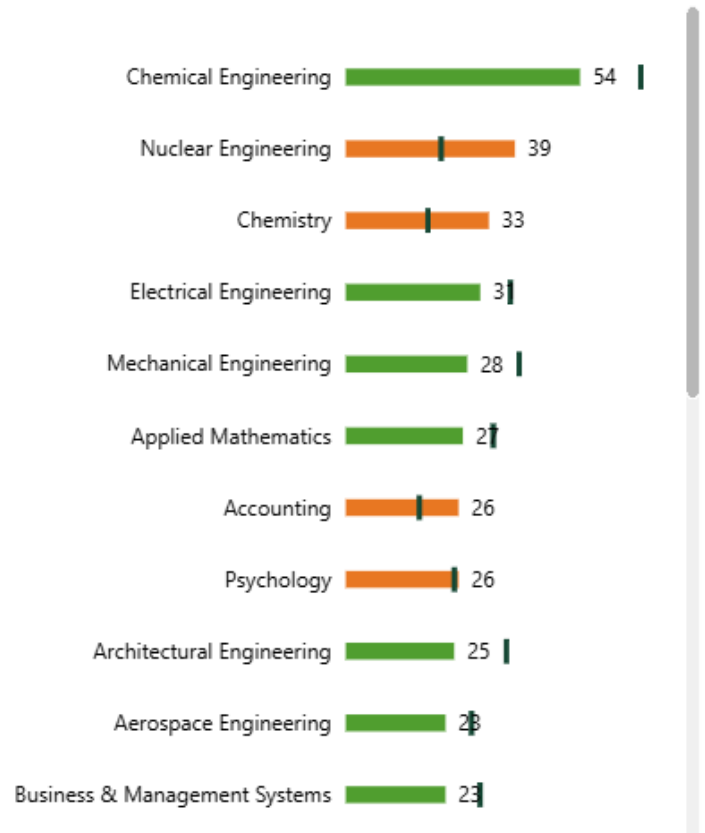
Students # by Advisor & Acad Level

Advisor	Freshman	Graduate	Junior	Senior	Sophomore
Arthur,Donna	6 ▲	—	2 ▼	4 ▼	5 ▲
Asbury,Nyhlamarie	4 ▲	—	1 ▼	3 ▲	3 ▲
Bassett,Kaleb Colt	2 ▼	—	3 ▲	4 ▲	3 ▲
Casey,Stephen Christopher	2 ▼	—	6 ▲	5 ▲	5 ▲
Cottrell,Norma-Gene	10 ▲	—	3 —	5 ▲	—
Flentje,Linda	2 ▲	—	1 ▼	6 ▲	7 ▲
Glidden,Tyler James	2 ▼	—	1 ▼	2 —	5 ▲
Hite,Tessa Corrinne	1 ▼	—	3 ▲	4 —	5 —
Lim,Chaw Koon Desiree	2 ▼	—	5 ▲	5 ▲	3 ▼
Long,Erica Lea	2 ▼	—	1 ▼	5 ▲	3 ▲
McCain,Jade Sierra	5 —	—	1 ▼	3 ▼	3 ▲
McMillen,Amy Louise	3 ▲	—	2 ▼	1 ▲	5 —
Meyers,Carl	1 ▼	—	2 ▲	4 ▲	4 ▲
North,Mallory Gail	4 ▲	—	4 ▲	5 ▲	1 ▼
Patel,Sunita	4 ▲	—	2 ▼	6 ▲	3 ▲
Runnion,Jennifer	5 ▲	—	5 ▲	4 ▲	1 ▲
Seely,Jody Kimberly	2 ▼	—	▼	3 —	6 ▲

Students # by Acad Standing (Current vs Prior)



Students # on Scholastic Probation by Acad Group



Advising

Advisor Name: All

Acad Plan: CHEM

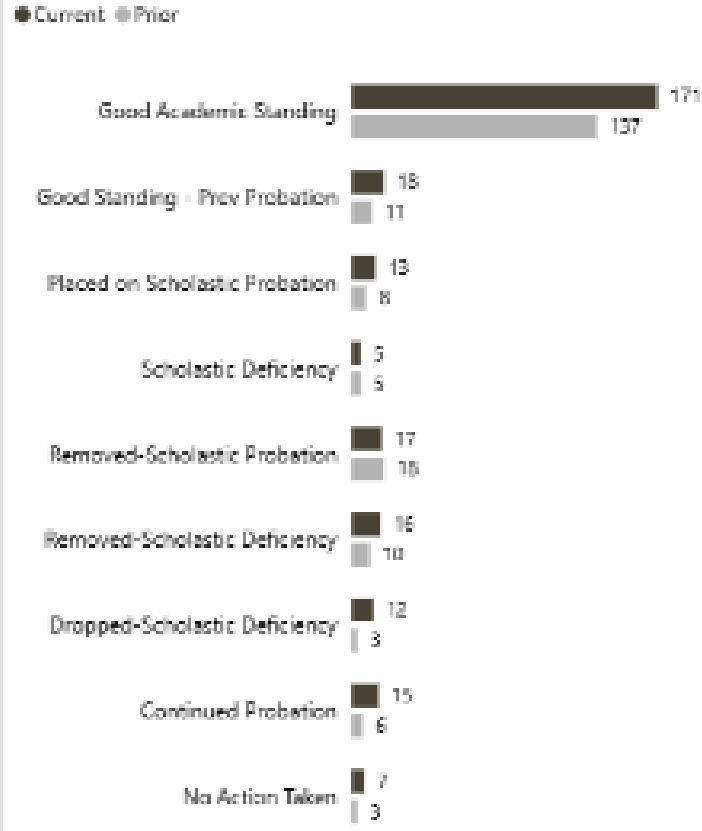
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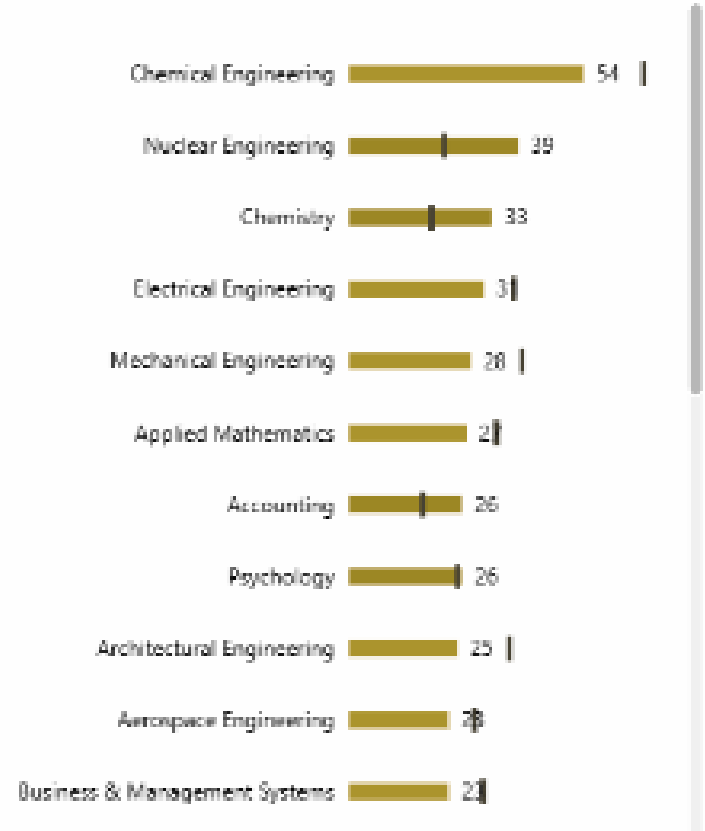
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Casey,Stephen Christopher	2 ▼	—	6 ▲	5 ▲	5 ▲
Cottrell,Norma-Gene	10 ▲	—	3 —	5 ▲	—
Flentje,Linda	2 ▲	—	1 ▼	6 ▲	7 ▲
Glidden,Tyler James	2 ▼	—	1 ▼	2 —	5 ▲
Hite,Tessa Corinne	1 ▼	—	3 ▲	4 —	5 —
Lim,Chaw Koon Desiree	2 ▼	—	5 ▲	5 ▲	3 ▼
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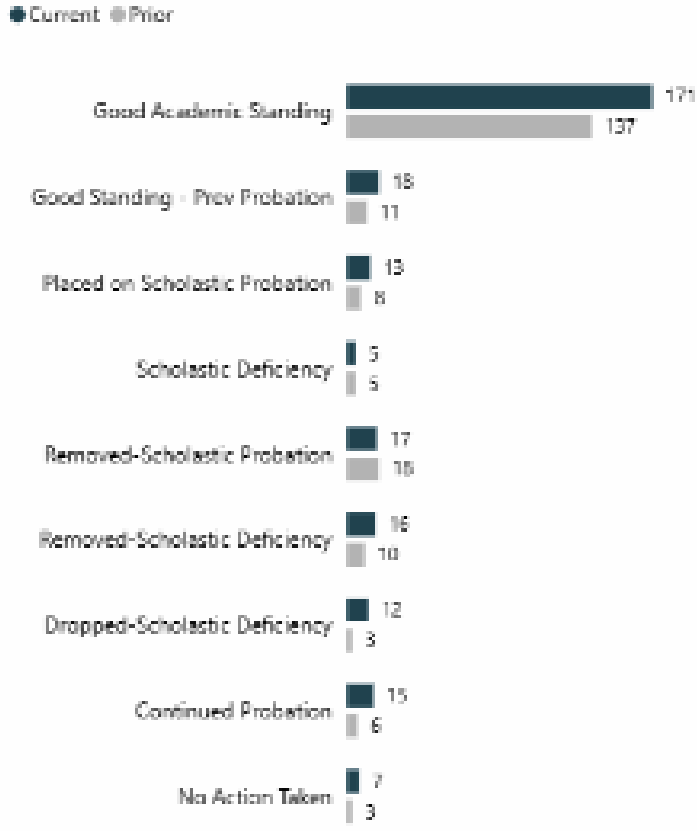
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Prior 201 (73 | 36.3% ▲)	Prior 19 (14 | 73.7% ▲)	UGRD # 51 · GRAD # --

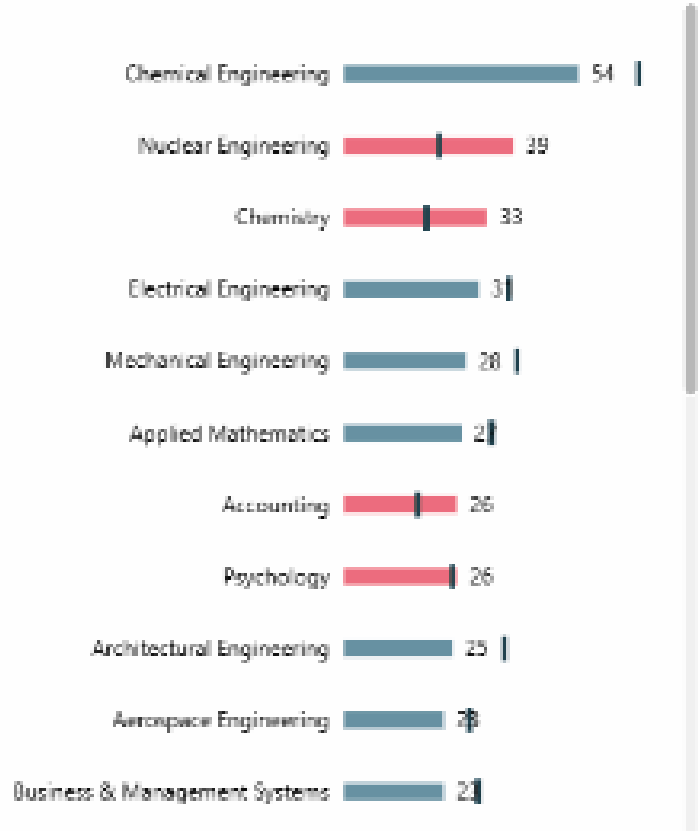
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Patel,Sunita	4 ▲	—	2 ▼	6 ▲	3 ▲
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Students # on Scholastic Probation by Acad Group



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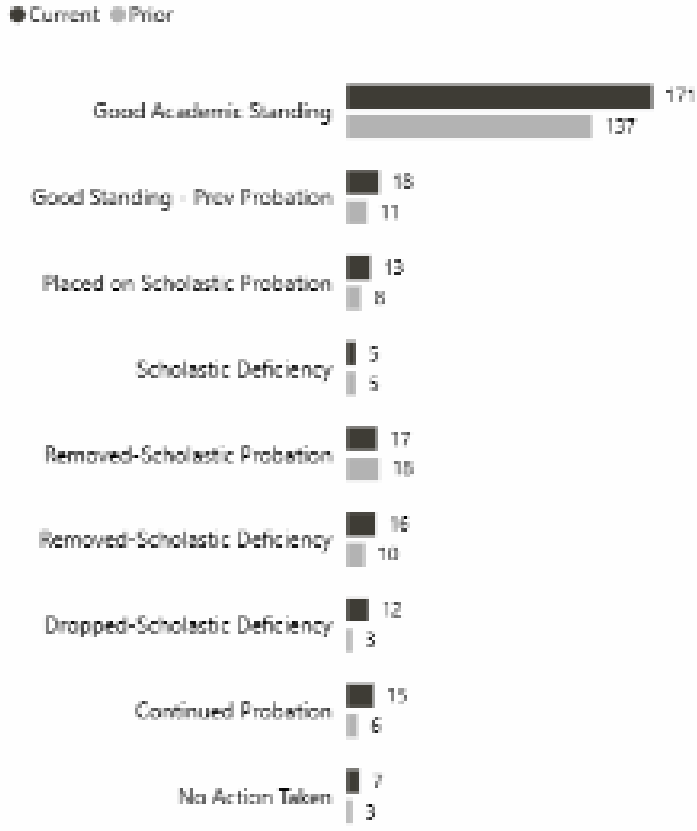
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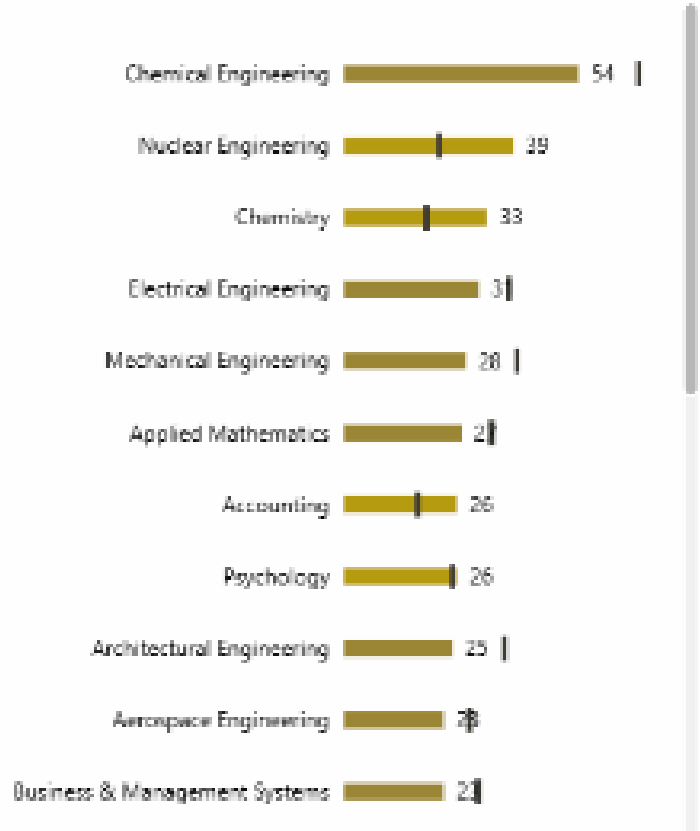
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Bassett,Kaleb Colt	2 ▼	—	3 ▲	4 ▲	3 ▲
Casey,Stephen Christopher	2 ▼	—	6 ▲	5 ▲	5 ▲
Cottrell,Norma-Gene	10 ▲	—	3 —	5 ▲	—
Flentje,Linda	2 ▲	—	1 ▼	6 ▲	7 ▲
Glidden,Tyler James	2 ▼	—	1 ▼	2 —	5 ▲
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Core Accessibility Features in Power BI

2. Alt Text & Screen Readers



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Screen readers are **software applications** that enable the visually impaired users to interact with computers and mobile devices by converting on-screen text, images, and interface elements into **speech** or **braille**.



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SCREEN READER	PLATFORM	NOTES
NVDA	Windows	Free and widely used
JAWS	Windows	Popular enterprise screen reader
Narrator (Windows+ Ctrl + Enter)	Windows	Built into Windows
VoiceOver	macOS / iPhone	Built into Apple devices

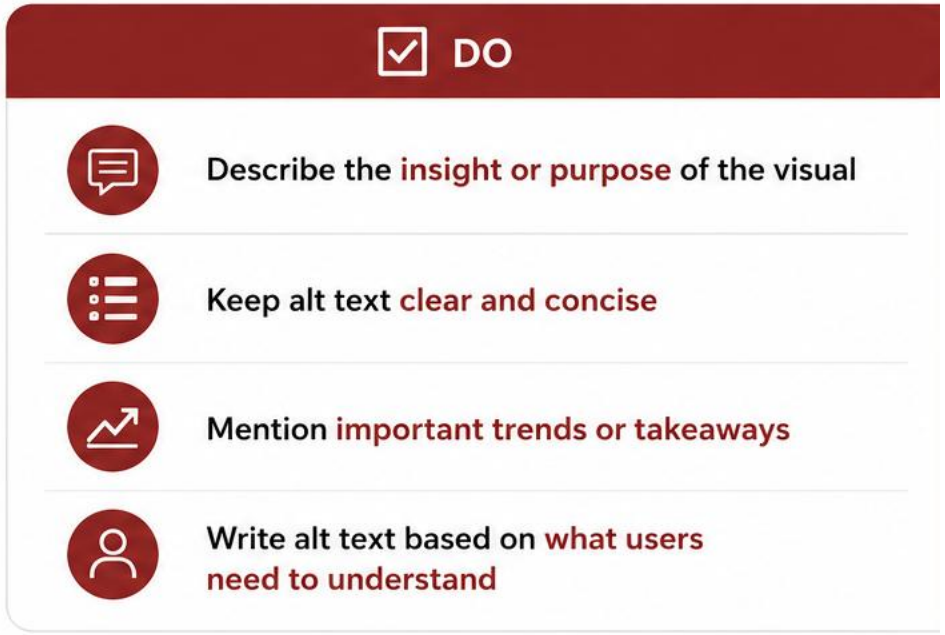
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2. Alt Text & Screen Readers

Every visual in Power BI can.. and should... have **alternative text.**
Screen readers announce it, making your insights available
to users who can't see the visual.

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air forum

2. Alt Text & Screen Readers

Every visual in Power BI can.. and should... have **alternative text.**
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to users who can't see the visual.

DO	DON'T
Describe the insight or purpose of the visual	Describe only the visual type ("Bar chart", "Line chart")
Keep alt text clear and concise	Write long paragraphs with unnecessary detail
Mention important trends or takeaways	Read out every single data point
Write alt text based on what users need to understand	Use generic text like "Image" or "Dashboard visual"

2. Alt Text & Screen Readers

Every visual in Power BI can.. and should... have **alternative text.**
Screen readers announce it, making your insights available
to users who can't see the visual.

DO	DON'T
Describe the insight or purpose of the visual	Describe only the visual type ("Bar chart", "Line chart")
Keep alt text clear and concise	Write long paragraphs with unnecessary detail
Mention important trends or takeaways	Read out every single data point
Write alt text based on what users need to understand	Use generic text like "Image" or "Dashboard visual"

Alt text should include **information about the insight**
that you'd like the report consumer to take away from a visual.

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Power BI Demo

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Core Accessibility Features in Power BI

3. Keyboard Navigation & Tab Order





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Keyboard navigation means users can interact with a dashboard **using only the keyboard**, without needing a mouse.

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WHY IT MATTERS

Some users:

- cannot use a mouse comfortably
- rely on assistive technologies
- navigate faster with keyboards
- use accessibility tools alongside keyboard controls

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KEYBOARD SHORTCUTS

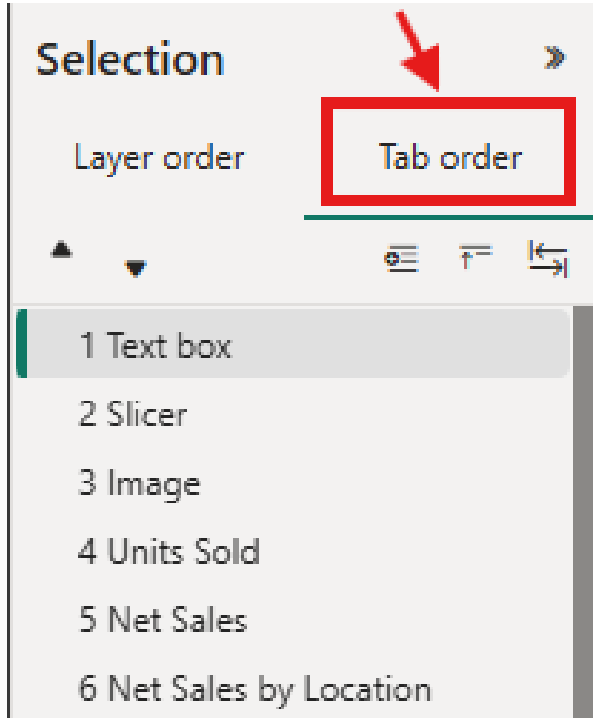
Tab	→ move between elements
Enter / Space	→ select or activate
Arrow keys	→ move within visuals or menus
Shift + Tab	→ move backward

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3. Keyboard Navigation & Tab Order

Setting the tab order helps **keyboard users** navigate your report in an order that matches the way users visually process the report visuals.

⚠️ If you include decorative shapes and images in your report, remove those elements from the tab order.



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Power BI Demo

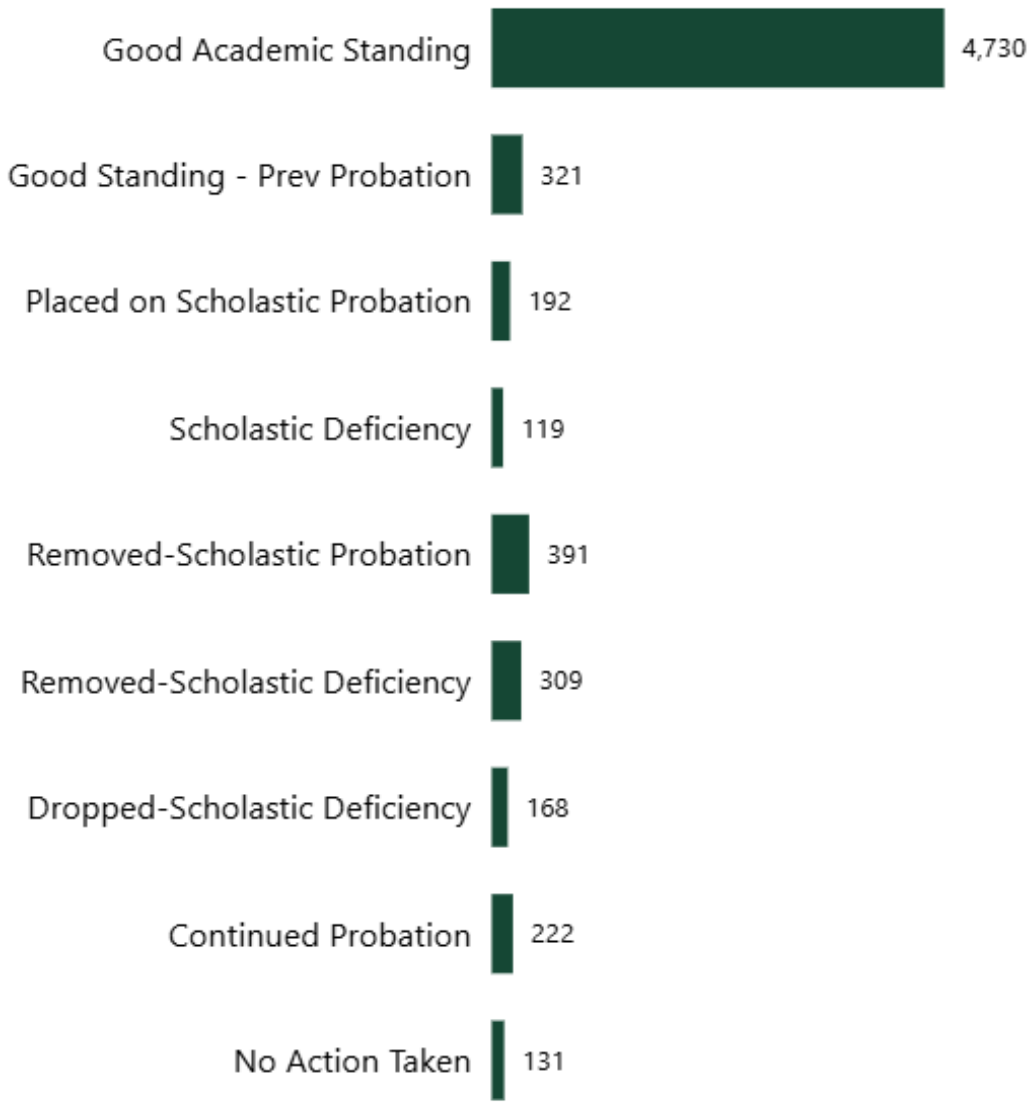
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Core Accessibility Features in Power BI

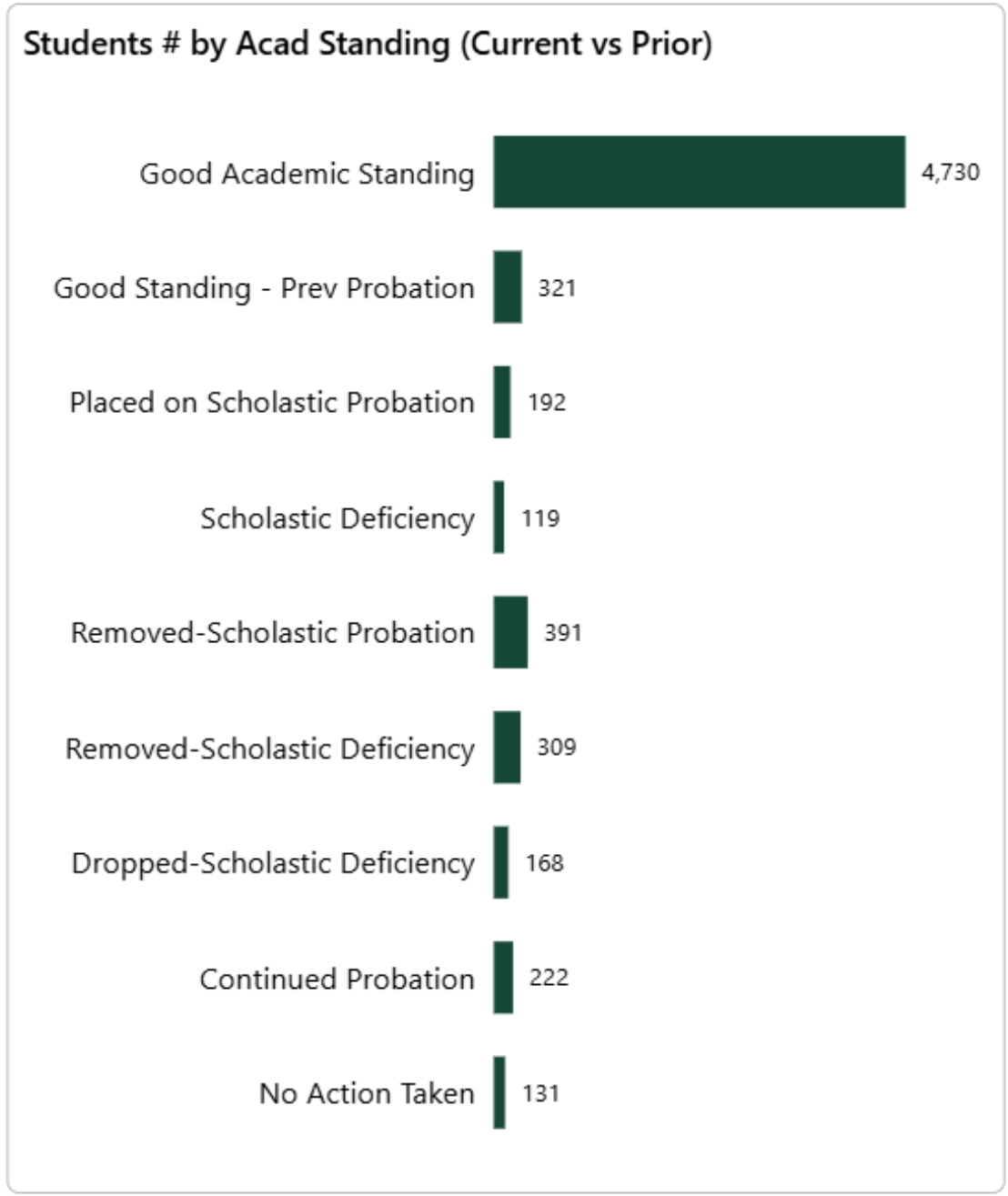
4. Accessible Interactions

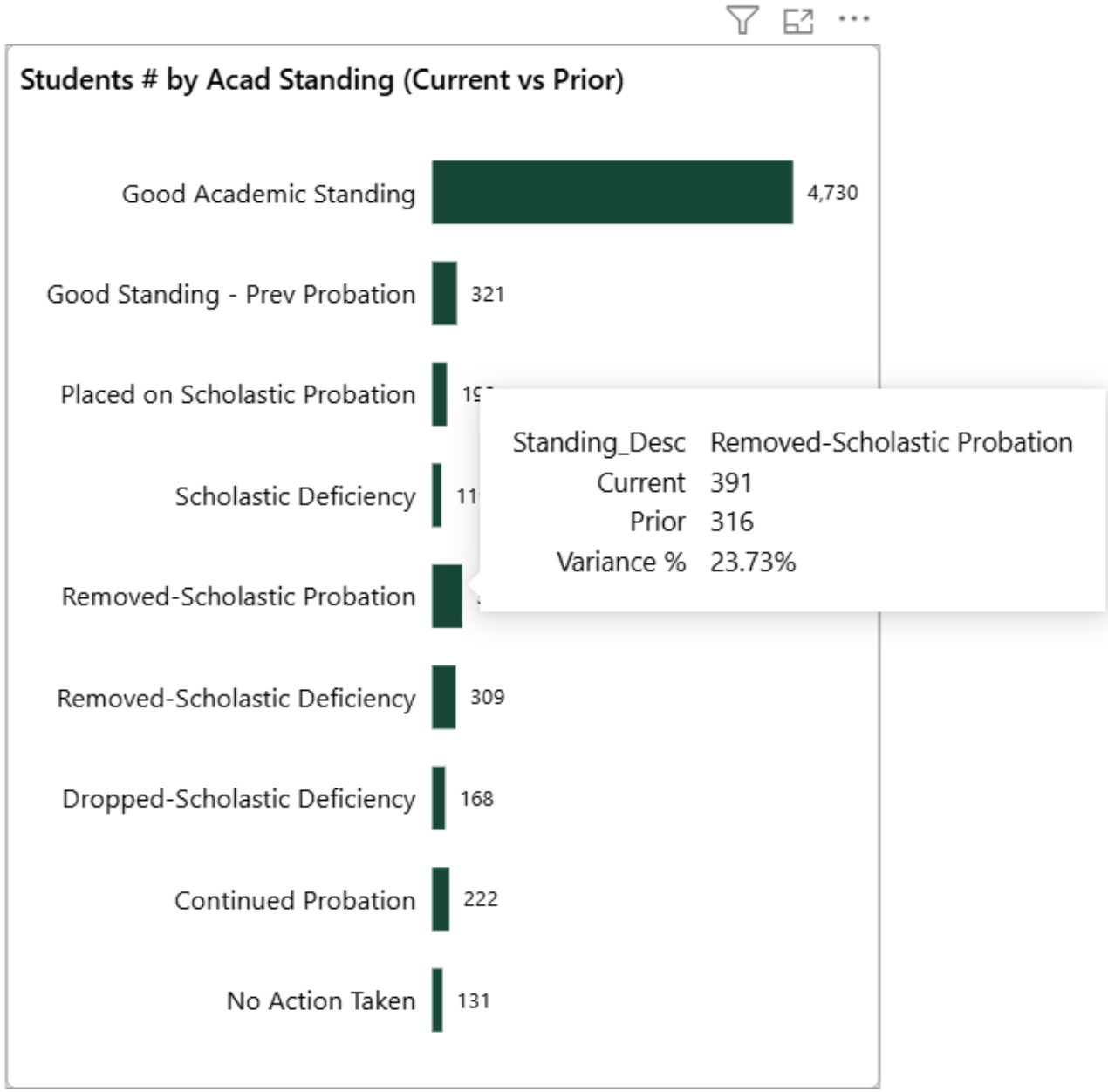


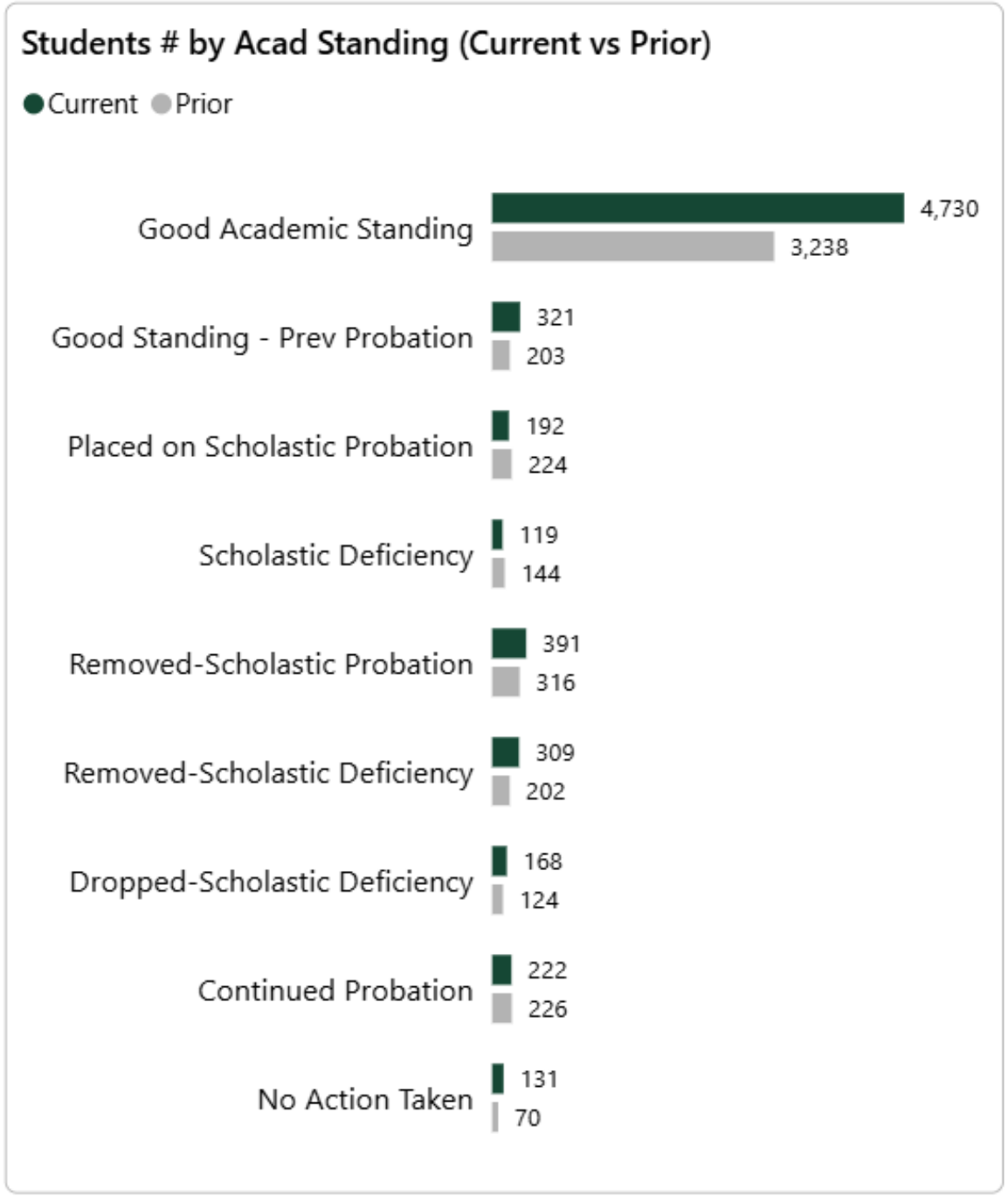
Students # by Acad Standing (Current vs Prior)



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Students # by Acad Standing (Current vs Prior)
Good Academic Standing
4,730
Good Standing - Prev Probation
321
Placed on Scholastic Probation
192
Scholastic Deficiency
119
Removed-Scholastic Probation
391
Removed-Scholastic Deficiency
309
Dropped-Scholastic Deficiency
168
Continued Probation
222
No Action Taken
131


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Removed-Scholastic Deficiency
309
Dropped-Scholastic Deficiency
168
Continued Probation
222
No Action Taken
131
Standing_Desc Removed-Scholastic Probation
Current 391
Prior 316
Variance % 23.73%


Students # by Acad Standing (Current vs Prior)
Current
Prior
Good Academic Standing
4,730
3,238
Good Standing - Prev Probation
321
203
Placed on Scholastic Probation
192
224
Scholastic Deficiency
119
144
Removed-Scholastic Probation
391
316
Removed-Scholastic Deficiency
309
202
Dropped-Scholastic Deficiency
168
124
Continued Probation
222
226
No Action Taken
131
70

4. Accessible Interactions



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Tooltips are supplemental, never sole

Important information should be visible without requiring hover interactions.



Avoid hidden navigation/interactions

Users should not have to "discover" how to use the dashboard.

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Visuals have clear titles and subtitles

Titles should explain what users are looking at and why it matters.



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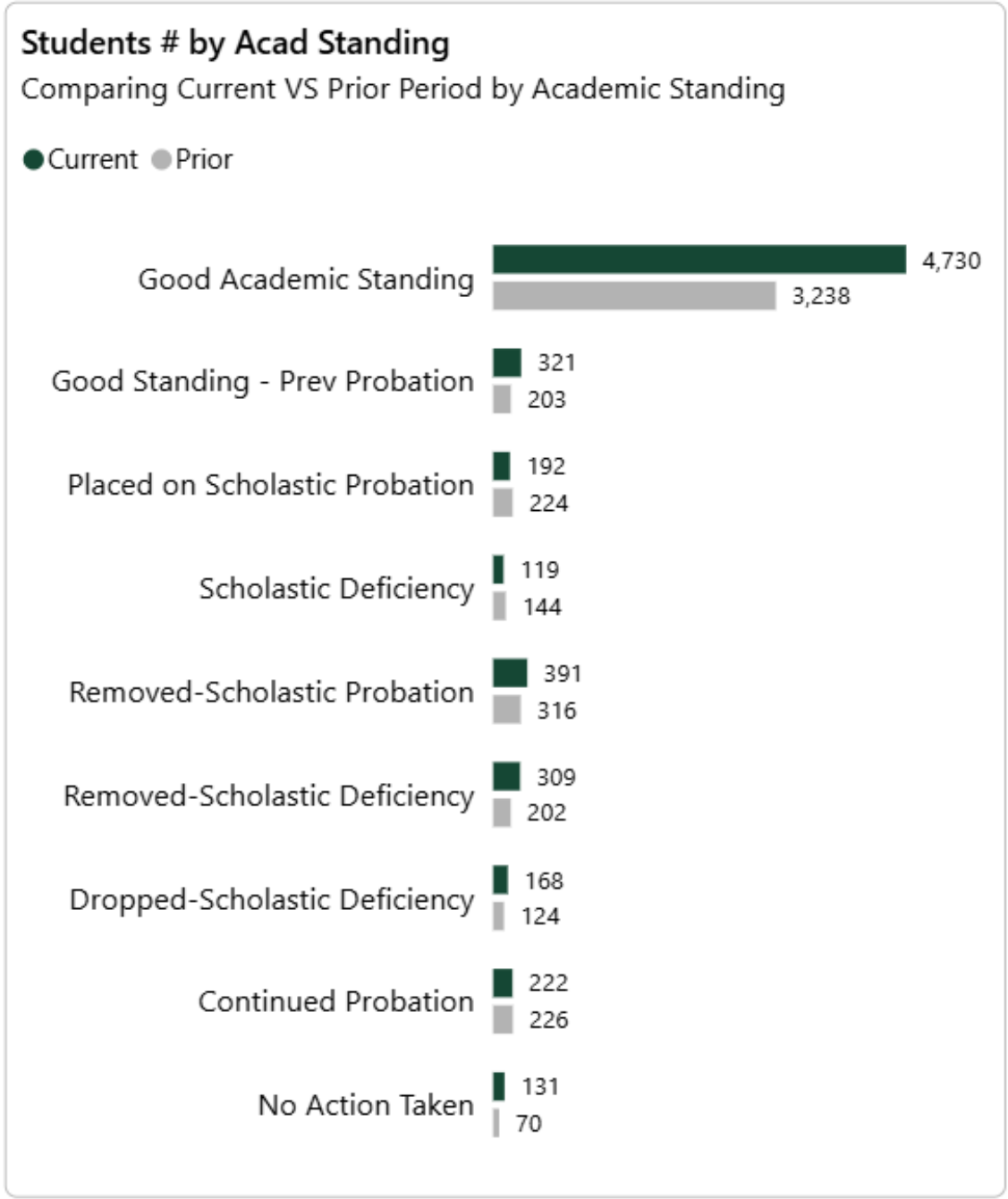
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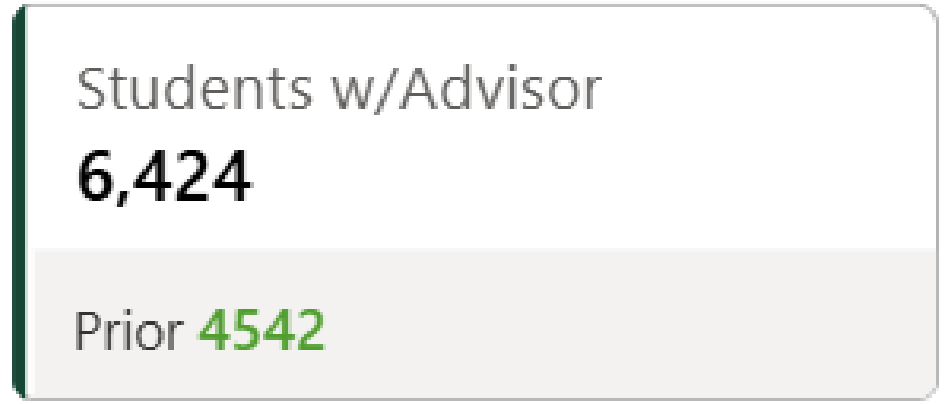
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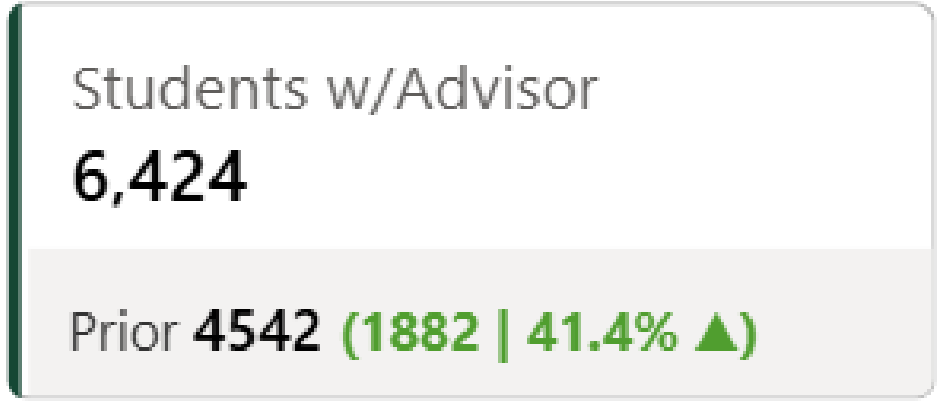
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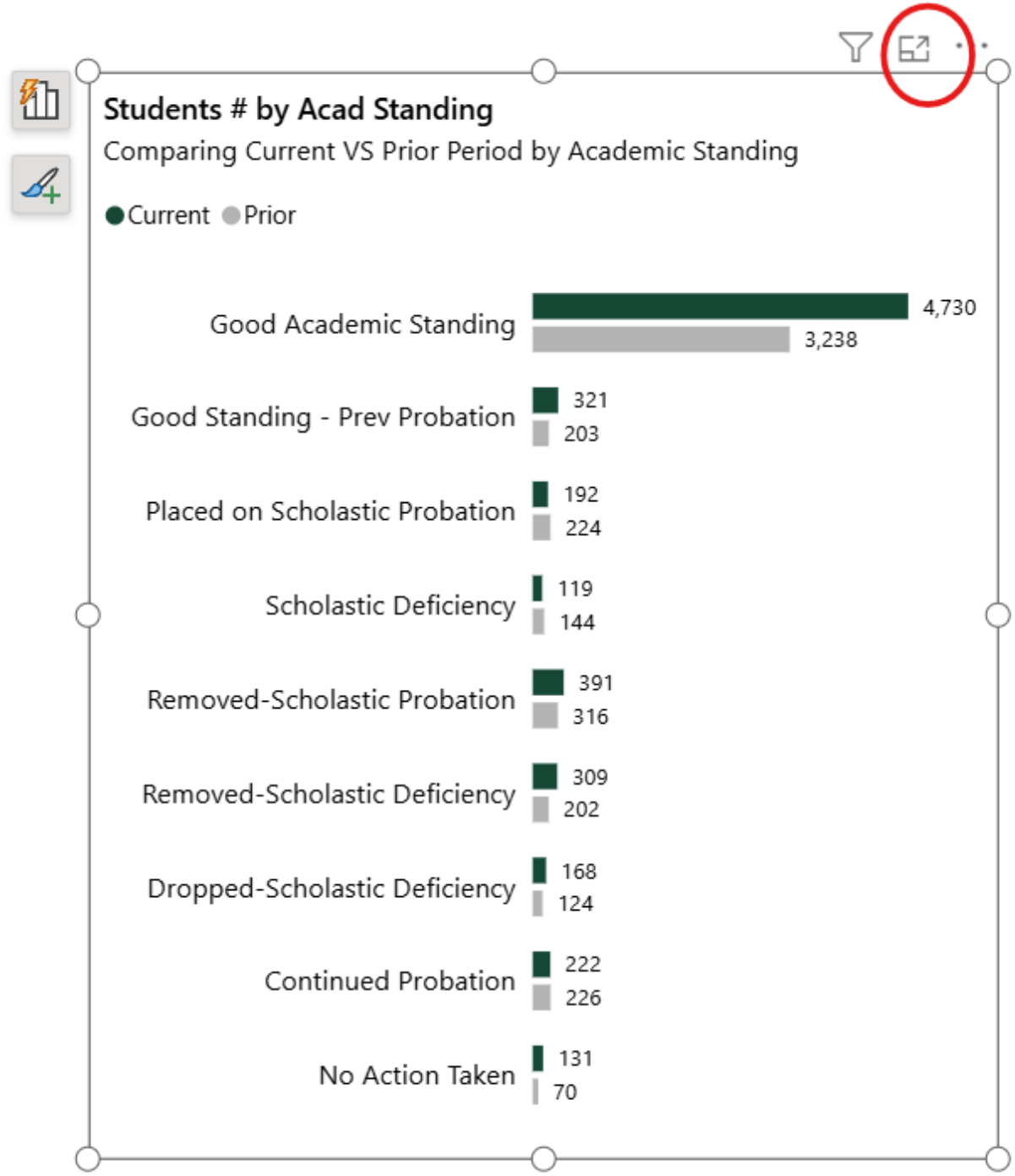
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Visual Properties ···

Data format

Header icons On

Colors

Icons

Visual information On

Visual warning On

Visual error On

Drill on dropdown On

Drill up On

Drill down On

Show next level On

Expand to next level On

Pin On

Focus mode On

See data layout On

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Don't use business jargons and acronyms

Use simple, familiar language that all users can understand quickly.

Next Steps

Your Accessibility Audit Checklist

Visual & Colour

- [x] Contrast ratio meets WCAG AA (4.5:1)
- [x] No colour-only indicators
- [x] Minimum 12pt font throughout
- [x] Accessible colour palette used



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Accessibility isn’t just a “special” feature you add at the end..

it's a quality standard baked into every design decision.







Don’t forget to rate this session and leave your feedback!

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Q&A